

ROS was developed in Willow Garage over a six-year period, until Willow closed in 2014. Many improvements to the project were made during that time. It was because of this drive during the Willow period that the show's popularity rose.

ROS Mango Tango, also known as ROS 0.4, was released in 2009 as the initial ROS distribution. As you can see, the first release's name had nothing to do with today's naming convention (for unknown reasons to this author). In 2010, the distribution's version 1.0 was released, almost a year later. The ROS team then chose to name the distributions after different turtle species. As a result, the following distributions and release dates have been established:

- Box Turtle, in 2010
- ROS C-Turtle, in 2010
- Diamond Back, in 2011
- ROS Electric Emys, in 2011
- ROS Fuerte Turtle, in 2012
- ROS Groovy Galapagos, in 2012

Another significant event that grew the ROS community was Willow Garage's announcement in 2011 of the introduction of the Turtlebot robot, the most well-known robot among ROS developers. Even if PR2 was the planned robot for ROS testing and development, its complexity and expensive cost rendered it unsuitable for most academics. The Turtlebot, on the other hand, was a simple and inexpensive robot that allowed anyone to play with the fundamentals of robotics and ROS. It was an instant hit, and its Turtlebot2 and Turtlebot 3 versions are still in use today.

The plan was for the newly formed Open Source Robotics Foundation to drive the development of ROS. Many of the staff were taken on by Suitable Technologies (one of Willow Garage's spin-offs, which, curiously, does not use ROS for its products. Clearpath Robotics, another prominent business, took over customer support for all PR2 robots.

Open Source Robotics Foundation

ROS continued to develop and distribute new releases under the OSRF's new legal framework:

- ROS Hydro Medusa, in 2013
- ROS Indigo Igloo, in 2014
- ROS Jade Turtle, in 2015
- ROS Kinetic Kame, in 2016